

Almost 70% of Americans today are either overweight or obese, but only 34% think they weigh too much. This is in contrast to 1990, when 54% of Americans were overweight or obese and 46% reported being at least somewhat overweight. In other words, the gap between what we weigh and what we *think* we weigh is getting bigger.

Epidemiologists argue that this discrepancy can be partly explained by the widespread resetting of norms regarding "normal weight" and "obesity." As close friends, coworkers, and family members gain weight, one's concept of what a body of acceptable weight looks like becomes modified. What was once considered overweight is now considered the norm, if only because it is so common (Figure 1).

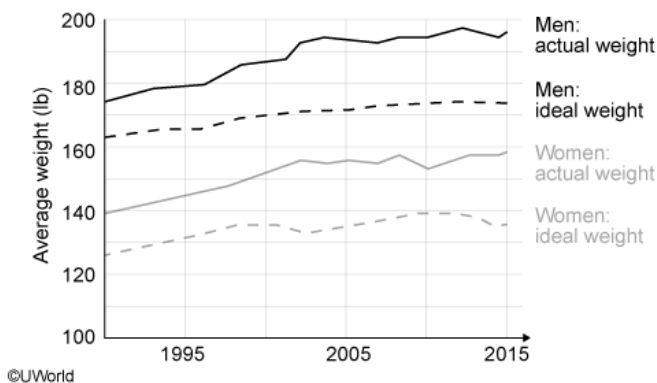


Figure 1 Actual vs. ideal weight (in pounds) for Americans, 1990–2015

This sheds new light on recent efforts to stop the obesity epidemic in America. Experts have long contended that awareness efforts don't work because overweight individuals are already aware that they are overweight and that obesity causes health problems. These latest data suggest that many overweight Americans don't even realize that they *are* overweight. Epidemiologists are now suggesting that a more successful strategy to get Americans to lose weight might be to first succeed at convincing them that being overweight is not normal.

Which statement about obesity is most consistent with the epidemiologists' argument in the second paragraph?

- ✔ ☒ A. Popular culture likely reflects changing attitudes about obesity.
[68%]

- ☐ B. Obesity is an American fad. [4%]
- ☐ C. Mass media is responsible for normalizing obesity. [14%]
- ☐ D. Obesity is a new counterculture in America. [12%]

Correct

67% answered correctly

Explanation:

Popular culture is defined as the **ideas, attitudes, and perspectives** that are **mainstream** (ie, relevant to most people in society). Popular culture includes anything the **majority** of individuals in a society believe in (eg, freedom), do (eg, watch television), wear (eg, blue jeans), or buy/consume (eg, cell phones, McDonald's meals).

Popular culture can be contrasted with high culture, which is relevant to a very small fraction of the population, usually those with wealth or education. For example, collecting museum-quality artwork is not considered part of popular culture.

The epidemiologists' argument in the second paragraph is that mainstream attitudes and beliefs regarding what is considered a healthy weight are changing as people gradually become heavier. Therefore, changing attitudes and beliefs about obesity are likely reflected in popular culture. In other words, people's beliefs, behaviors, and consumer habits (ie, aspects of popular culture) reflect changing attitudes about obesity.

(Choice B) Fads are trends or crazes occurring over a short period within a segment of the population. For example, wearing bell-bottom pants was a fad for hippies in the 1960s. The second paragraph states that resetting of norms regarding weight is widespread with no endpoint suggested, which is inconsistent with a fad.

(Choice C) Mass media includes all the routes through which information reaches large numbers of people in society (eg, television, Internet). The argument made by the epidemiologists in the second paragraph is that *interaction with friends and family* (not mass media) is responsible for normalizing obesity.

(Choice D) Countercultures are subsets of society that resist mainstream values and norms. Countercultural movements are the opposition of mainstream culture (eg, anti-consumerism) by a clearly defined group (eg, hippies in the 1960s and 1970s). The second paragraph suggests that the resetting of norms regarding weight is a mainstream, widespread phenomenon not limited to a counterculture.

Educational objective:

Popular culture refers to ideas, attitudes, and behaviors that are widespread in society. Popular culture reflects the beliefs and behaviors of the masses, whereas high culture is relevant to only a small fraction (eg, those who are wealthy and/or educated).

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID:400813

System:

Identity and Social Interaction

Almost 70% of Americans today are either overweight or obese, but only 34% think they weigh too much. This is in contrast to 1990, when 54% of Americans were overweight or obese and 46% reported being at least somewhat overweight. In other words, the gap between what we weigh and what we *think* we weigh is getting bigger.

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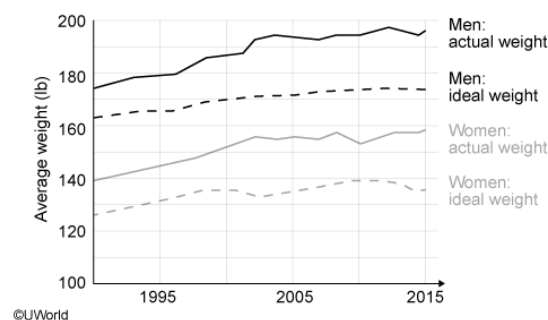


Figure 1 Actual vs. ideal weight (in pounds) for Americans, 1990–2015

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How has the evolution of human culture most likely contributed to the current obesity epidemic?

- ☒ A. People tend to eat larger food portions than ever before. [62%]
- ☐ B. Fat storage efficiency increased chances of survival during times of famine. [7%]
- ☐ C. Being overweight was once associated with wealth and power. [19%]
- ☐ D. Calorie-dense foods are innately desirable to most humans. [10%]

Correct

62% answered correctly

Explanation:

Biological evolution	Cultural evolution
Genetic traits from parent to offspring	Behavioral traits between related or unrelated individuals

Occurs from one generation to the next	Occurs between or within generations
Slow, over the course of many generations	May occur slowly or quickly
Independent of learning	Results from teaching, education, or scientific progress
Transmission by way of genes	Transmission by way of language, behavior

Changes in human behavior over time can occur because of biological and/or cultural evolution. Biological evolution influences human behavior through natural selection of genes. For example, the genes controlling the production of lactase (the enzyme that breaks down lactose in dairy) tend to be turned off after infancy. However, a mutation resulting in lactase production into adulthood for some individuals (biological evolution) corresponds with increased consumption of dairy products by adults in certain cultures (behavior change).

Cultural evolution describes **changes in human values, practices**, and/or **beliefs** that are *not* due to genes. For example, sterile practices were introduced to modern medicine in 1846. The link between "germs" and disease was not discovered until the 1860s, so surgeons would routinely conduct autopsies and then deliver babies without washing their hands or instruments, resulting in an extremely high rate of maternal and fetal death. Most doctors initially thought hand washing and sterilization were ludicrous, but when these practices were implemented, mortality rates dropped dramatically.

Increasing food portions, a behavioral change not associated with genetics, is also an example of cultural evolution, one that is contributing to the current obesity epidemic.

(Choice B) Fat storage efficiency does increase survival during famine, but this is an example of biological (not cultural) evolution.

(Choice C) Those with wealth and power were the only individuals with consistent access to food, which used to be scarce. Food is now widely accessible, so this does not help explain the current obesity epidemic.

(Choice D) Calorie-dense foods are innately desirable to humans; this preference evolved because these foods provide more efficient energy, making it another example of biological (not cultural) evolution.

Educational objective:

Changes in human behavior occur because of biological evolution (natural selection of genetic traits) or cultural evolution. Cultural evolution occurs when socially transmitted beliefs and values result in changes in behavior.

Time spent: 0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID: 400814
System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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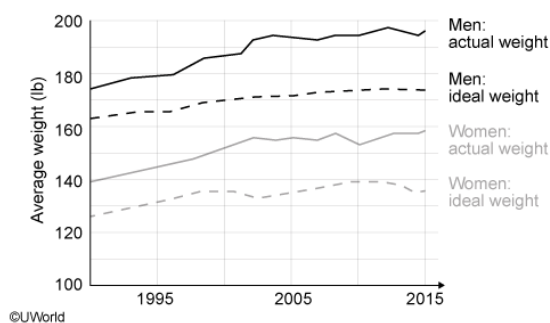


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The second paragraph describes:

- ☐ A. cultural diffusion within in-groups. [29%]
- ☐ B. cultural transmission between in-groups and out-groups. [9%]
- ☐ C. peer pressure caused by reference groups. [3%]
- ✓ ☒ D. socialization by primary and secondary groups. [57%]

Correct

57% answered correctly

Explanation:

Types of groups	
In-group	- Group to which an individual identifies & belongs - Other in-group members viewed favorably

Out-group	• Group to which an individual does not identify or belong • Out-group members viewed unfavorably
Reference group	• Comparison group to which an individual compares self • Individual may or may not <i>belong</i> to this group
Primary group	• Group of individuals who are emotionally close • Smaller in size, high degree of interaction (eg, family)
Secondary group	• Group of individuals who come together to accomplish something • Larger in size, more impersonal (eg, coworkers)

Primary groups are composed of a small number of individuals sharing **close, informal**, and **enduring** personal relationships. Examples of primary groups include families, close friends, and couples in loving relationships.

Secondary groups, on the other hand, are composed of individuals coming together to **accomplish something**. Relationships between secondary group members are not as enduring or intimate as those between primary group members. Examples of secondary groups include classmates and coworkers.

Socialization involves learning the norms and values of a society or culture. The second paragraph describes the way members of primary and secondary groups ("close friends, coworkers, and family members") are socialized into accepting the new standards of what a normal body should look like.

(Choice A) Cultural diffusion is the spread of beliefs and behaviors from one cultural group to another. Cultural diffusion describes *exchange between out-groups*, such as the popularity of sushi (Japanese cuisine) in America.

(Choice B) Cultural transmission is the passing of knowledge and values to the next generation. Cultural transmission occurs *within in-groups* through education and socialization.

(Choice C) A reference group is a comparison group to which an individual may or may not belong. For example, a pre-med student might compare her MCAT scores to those of her classmates (in-group) or first-year medical students (out-group). The second paragraph describes reference groups, but it does not describe peer pressure, which is the influence exerted by a group on an individual to conform in order to be liked or accepted.

Educational objective:

Primary groups consist of members who share close, enduring personal relationships and who care about each other (eg, family members). Secondary groups exist to carry out functions and consist of members whose relationships are less intimate and enduring (eg, coworkers).

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Identity and Social Interaction

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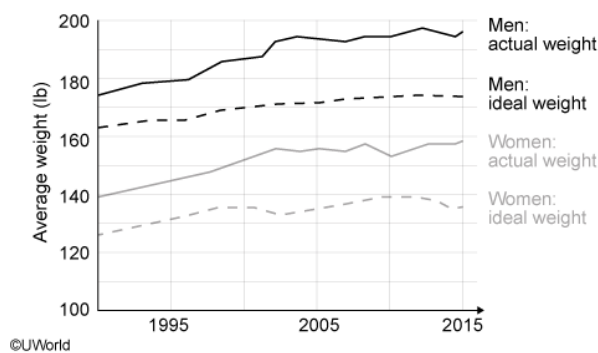


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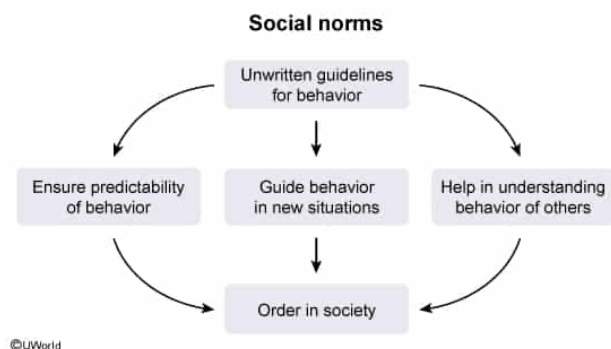
According to the last paragraph, the challenge faced by epidemiologists is:

- ☐ A. encouraging social stigma. [4%]
- ☐ B. overriding social sanctions. [2%]
- ☐ C. reorganizing social networks.
- ☒ D. resetting social norms. [93%]

Correct

93% answered correctly

Explanation:



Social norms are **unwritten rules for behavior** that people in society are expected to follow (eg, chewing with a closed mouth). Unlike laws, which are more formally enforced, disobeying social norms is often informally punished (eg, getting stared at or shunned).

Social norms **maintain order in society** by ensuring that behavior is predictable. Social norms also provide guidelines for how to behave in various situations and help individuals decode and understand the behavior of others.

As the body weight of the average American has increased, obesity has become the norm rather than the exception. Epidemiologists face the challenge of *resetting social norms* so that obesity is again considered unhealthy and unacceptable.

(Choice A) Social stigma is the association of shame with a particular trait, caused by extreme social disapproval. Obesity is often stigmatized; however, the final paragraph does not suggest that epidemiologists need to encourage disapproval or shame.

(Choice B) Social sanctions are penalties (eg, fines, jail time) for breaking rules or laws. The final paragraph makes no mention of having to override social sanctions to solve the obesity epidemic.

(Choice C) Social networks are informal ties between people (eg, Facebook friends). The final paragraph does not suggest that epidemiologists need to reorganize social networks to solve the obesity problem.

Educational objective:

Social norms are unwritten rules that members of a society are expected to follow to maintain order. Social norms ensure predictable behavior, provide guidelines for behavior in new situations, and help individuals understand the behavior of others.

Time spent: 0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID: 400816

System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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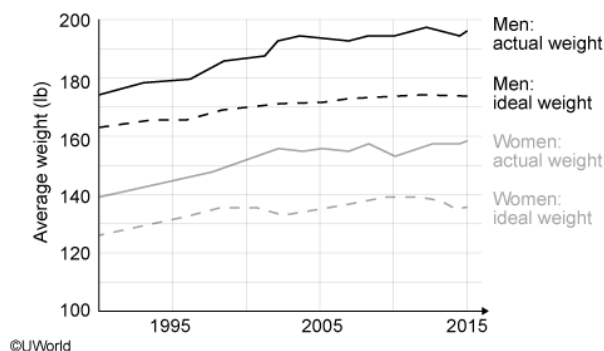


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Which of the following conclusions is supported by Figure 1?

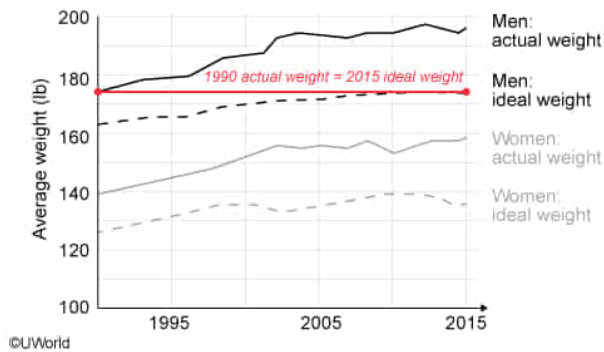
- ☐ A. The average American's actual weight has consistently increased since 2005. [13%]
- ☐ B. The difference between Americans' actual and ideal weights has doubled since 2000. [15%]
- ☒ C. The average American man's ideal weight in 2015 was approximately the same as his actual weight in 1990. [68%]
- ☐ D. The average American woman's actual and ideal weights have

converged over time. [2%]

Correct

68% answered correctly

Explanation:



According to Figure 1, American men, on average, actually weighed about 176 lb in 1990 and reported an ideal weight of about 176 lb in 2015. Therefore, the average American man's ideal weight in 2015 was approximately the same as his actual weight in 1990.

(Choice A) According to Figure 1, the average weight for women dropped in the years 2008–2010, and the average weight for men dropped in 2012–2014. Therefore, Americans did not *consistently* gain weight every year.

(Choice B) The difference between actual and ideal weight for men was about 18 lb in 2000 and about 20 lb in 2015. The difference between actual and ideal weight for women was about 20 lb in 2000 and about 22 lb in 2015. The difference between the average American's actual and ideal weights has approximately doubled since 1990, not since 2000.

(Choice D) From 1990 to 2015, the difference between women's actual and ideal weights has actually *diverged* (gotten bigger), not converged (gotten smaller). In 25 years, the difference has increased from about 12 to 24 lb.

Time spent: 0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID: 400817
System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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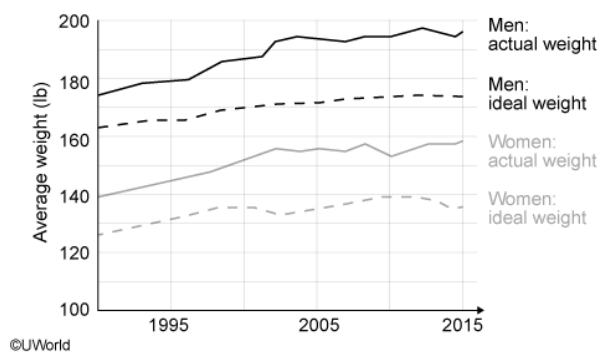


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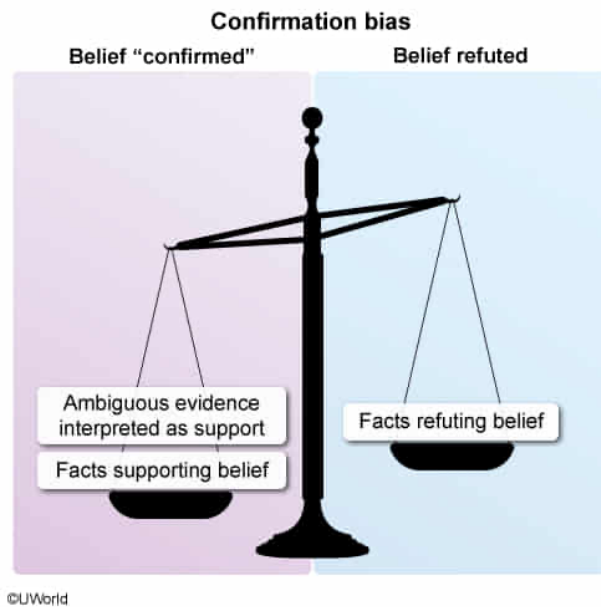
Based on the information in the final paragraph, a successful strategy for promoting weight loss would be to counteract which cognitive bias?

- ☒ A. Confirmation [49%]
- ☐ B. Self-serving [36%]
- ☐ C. Actor-observer [9%]
- ☐ D. Hindsight [5%]

Correct

48% answered correctly

Explanation:



Confirmation bias is a type of cognitive bias (common error in thinking) in which individuals tend to **embrace evidence supporting** their beliefs, dismiss or **ignore evidence refuting** their beliefs, and interpret **ambiguous evidence as support**. For example, an individual who prefers a particular presidential candidate might listen only to media reports predicting a win while ignoring other evidence that the candidate will lose.

According to the passage, overweight Americans may not realize they are overweight due to changing social norms about acceptable body size. As others (friends, coworkers) gain weight, being overweight tends to look increasingly normal, making it easier to believe that being too heavy is merely average. In other words, overweight Americans might look only at evidence confirming their belief that their own weight is normal, ignoring evidence that it is not. Therefore, a successful strategy for promoting weight loss would be to *counteract confirmation bias*.

(Choice B) Self-serving bias occurs when success is credited to internal factors but failure is blamed on external factors. For example, a good grade is attributed to being smart (internal), whereas a bad grade is attributed to the questions being unfair (external). The passage does not discuss how individuals attribute success or failure.

(Choice C) Actor-observer bias occurs when an individual is more likely to blame his or her own bad behavior on external circumstances. For example, an individual may cut someone off in traffic, but would excuse their behavior due to running late. The passage does not discuss how individuals attribute their behavior.

(Choice D) Hindsight bias is a cognitive bias in which an event is perceived as being likely or predictable after it has occurred, even if it was not likely to happen. For example, after a team scores an upset victory, people might declare that they knew it would happen all along.

Educational objective:

Confirmation bias is a type of cognitive bias in which an individual believes evidence supporting pre-existing beliefs, dismisses or ignores evidence refuting beliefs, and interprets ambiguous evidence as support.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400818

System:
Identity and Social Interaction